REP-007 · PLAN-005 proposed: make 4-player games easy to find

Game	Fruit Market
Report date	2026-10-26 18:36 (Asia/Kuala_Lumpur)
Build	`main @ cc27848` (live game still 1.1.0)
Type	Planning only. **No game implementation changes were made.** One read-only test was run locally.
Approval status	PLAN-005 **awaiting approval** (DEC-012)

1 · What you noticed

You couldn't see an option for 4 human players. 4-player games are supported, but the screens don't say so.

Online room (Play a friend), as it looks today on a 360 px phone:

- The heading says **"Invite a friend"** (singular).
- There is one empty row: **"Waiting for a friend to join"**, which disappears once one person joins.
- The count "1/4" is in small grey text next to "Players".

Same phone (New game): 4 people means choosing **3** rival shops and switching each from Computer to Friend. Nothing on the screen explains that.

Quick match is always 2 strangers, by design. Nothing points groups to Play a friend instead.

2 · Check that 4 players really work (read-only, local server)

- 4 browsers joined one room by the same link. The lobby showed "Players 4/4". All 4 pressed ready, the host started, and **all 4 reached the game** (each saw 3 rivals).
- A **5th** person was turned away: "Couldn't join · This room is full."
- Limitation: tested on one machine, not 4 real phones. The automated test below makes this a permanent check.

3 · PLAN-005 · 4-player clarity

Player problem: groups of 3 or 4 think the game is for 2 and give up, or play with computers instead.

Included scope (screen text and layout only)

Screen	Today	Proposed
Online lobby, invite box	"Invite a friend"	**"Invite friends (up to 3)"**
Online lobby, player list	"Players 1/4" (small, grey), one row "Waiting for a friend to join"	**"Players 1 of 4"** in normal text, plus one row per free seat: "Open seat · send the link"
Online lobby, when full	(nothing)	"Room full · start when everyone is ready"
Home, under "Play a friend"	(nothing)	Small line: "2 to 4 players online"
Quick match screen	(nothing)	"Quick match is always 2 players. For 3 or 4, use Play a friend."
New game, under "Rival shops"	(nothing)	"Up to 4 shops. Pick Friend to pass this phone around." plus a live total, for example "4 shops: you, 2 friends, 1 computer"

Computer shops added in the lobby take seats, so the open-seat rows and the count include them. For example: 2 people + 1 computer = "Players 3 of 4", one open seat.

Also included: a new automated browser test where 4 people join one room and all reach the game, and a 5th is refused. It runs in CI on every change.

Excluded

- Rules, balance, the 4-player limit and quick-match size.
- Any server or message change.
- Renaming the buttons people tap to get there ("Play a friend", "New game"), so tests and habits keep working.
- Publishing.

Roles: UX designer (wording), gameplay engineer, QA. Self-review; low risk.

Likely files: `src/ui/Online.tsx` (lobby), `src/ui/App.tsx` (home, new game), `src/ui/styles.css`, new `scripts/e2e-four.cjs`, `scripts/e2e.mjs`.

Acceptance (observable)

- C1. The lobby shows "Players N of 4" and one open-seat row per free seat. Both update when people join or leave and when computer shops are added.
- C2. With 4 people there are no open seats and the lobby says the room is full.
- C3. The new browser test passes: 4 people join one room, all see the game, and a 5th is refused.
- C4. The new lines fit on a 360 px wide phone without overflow (screenshots of each screen in the report).
- C5. Store screenshots change only where intended (home and lobby text), checked with the visual-diff tool.
- C6. `verify:full` is green in CI; no rules, server or save changes.

Cost and data: RM0. No data changes.

Risks: longer text could wrap awkwardly on small phones; C4 checks this. Wording is a matter of taste, so you can change any line before or after.

Rollback: revert the package commit.

After it's built: open the preview, tap Play a friend → Create room, and check that the lobby clearly invites up to 3 friends.

4 · Decision

ID	Question	Recommendation	Status
DEC-012	How to make 4-player play easy to find	Screen text and open-seat rows plus a 4-person test (PLAN-005); no rule or server change	Awaiting approval

5 · Note on order

The reconnect fix (PLAN-004) is on the preview and not live yet. PLAN-005 can be built first and both can go out together in 1.1.1, which saves you one Deploy.